

Research Seminar

Research Proposal

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January 14, 2026

Outline

① Research Proposal

② Thesis Proposal

Purposes of Research Proposals

- suggest a research task
- apply for a research job
- apply for research money

Content of Research Proposals

- description of research topic
- description of related work
- description of research statements and contributions
- description of material and methods
- description of work plan

Research Proposals vs. Research Articles

- The phrasing of research proposals has many similarities to that of scientific articles.
- Like scientific articles, research proposals have sections describing the research background, significance, methods, and references.
- But: Research proposals are written in future tense and have different points of emphasis.
- A typical research proposal includes an extensive but focused literature review.
- The method section of research proposals is far more detailed than those of scientific articles, allowing profound understanding of the price and risks of the study and the plans for reducing them.
- Instead of a section describing the results, research proposals have a section describing the hypotheses or the expected results.

Outline

① Research Proposal

② Thesis Proposal

Thesis Proposal

- The proposal for a thesis or dissertation is essentially an **outline of the research** – like an architectural blueprint for building a house.
- The clearer the plan, the more **timely and successful the completion**.
- The clearer the plan, the more likely it is that **it will be approved**.
- The proposal **forces you to think through the whole project** from beginning to end, so you will be able to **anticipate problems** that may occur during the course of your study, and to be prepared for them.
- If you have an idea about where you are going **it's easier to get there**.

Research Title

- contains a **short, descriptive title** of the proposed thesis project
- should be fairly **self-explanatory**
- contains author, institution, department, research mentor, mentor's institution, and date of delivery

Introduction to your Research Topic

- set the context for your proposed project
- capture the reader's interest
- explain the background of your study starting from a broad picture narrowing in on your research question

Related Work

- review what is known about your research topic as far as it is relevant to your thesis
- integrated statement that explains why these studies or theories are important to your research
- cite only relevant references

Research Statement

- in a couple of sentences, **state your thesis**
- can take the form of a **hypothesis**, research **question**, or **goal** statement
- should capture the **essence** of your intended project and also help to put **boundaries** around it

Research Contributions

- implications of your research
- what new knowledge will the proposed project produce that we do not already know?
- why is it worth knowing?
- what are the major implications?

Materials and Methods

- overall description of your approach, materials, and procedures:
 - what methods will be used?
 - how will data be collected and analysed?
 - what materials will be used?
- include calculations, technique, procedure, and equipment
- detail limitations, assumptions, and range of validity

Work Plan

- describe in detail what you plan to do until completion of your thesis
- list the stages of your project (e.g., in a table format)
- indicate deadlines and milestones you have set for completing each stage of the project (including work you have already completed)
- discuss any particular challenges that need to be overcome

Proposal Template – SSiW

1. Topic & Motivation

Describe the topic you are interested in and say which questions you want to answer in your thesis. You may want to mention where/how you got interested in the topic. Examples usually help to illustrate the topic and the questions.

2. Related Work

Select references that are relevant for your research. Cite the references properly and describe the respective studies.

3. Statement & Contributions

Describe what your research will provide as novelties to the research field.

4. Materials and Methods

Describe which material you will need for your study and which methods you will apply.

5. Work Plan

Develop a schedule for your thesis work. Minimally, the schedule should contain the start and the end dates and 3-5 milestones (dates and achievements) in between.